While he fought his way doggedly forward, another Mongol division, commanded by the general Sartaq, made its way towards Goryeo. In the summer of 1231, they reached the Yalu river and prepared to attack.

It was not the first time that the Mongols had been to the Yalu. Back in 1218, during Genghis Khan's push westward, a Mongol detachment had chased fleeing steppe peoples known as the Khitan into the peninsula. When the Khitan holed up at the Goryeo city of Kangdong, the Mongols asked the military dictator Choe Chung-heon to send them aid.

Choe Chung-heon had agreed, cautiously; as one of his officials pointed out, the Mongols were known to be "the most inhuman of the northern barbarians." But another advisor, the Commissioner of Men and Horse, warned, "If we disregard them, I believe we will regret it later." To prevent reprisals, Chung-heon sent troops and provisions: a thousand men and a thousand bags of rice.[1]

Once they had defeated the Khitan, the Mongols demanded tribute as payment for delivering Goryeo from the Khitan menace, and then left; most of them, anyway. Forty-one men, according to the *Goryeo-sa*, were left at the border town Uiju. "Practice the language of Goryeo," they were instructed, "and wait for our return."[2]

Now, in 1231, the Mongols were back. On August 26, General Sartaq ordered his men to cross the Yalu, and the war to swallow Goryeo began.

By 1231, Choe Chung-heon was dead; his son Choe-U headed the military state that had enfolded Goryeo's civil government. A figurehead monarch, King Gojong, still sat on the throne, but Choe-U was responsible for facing the Mongol threat.

As the Mongols advanced, the towns in front of them emptied, the people surrendering or fleeing. Choe-U called the standing army of Goryeo out to face the enemy. Unexpectedly reinforced by five thousand outlaws, sent by the notorious bandit chief Yu-ke-hsia from his hiding place near the Yalu, the Goryeo army put up a startlingly fierce resistance. The northwestern city Kuju held out so stubbornly that the Mongols themselves paid grudging respect: "I am accustomed to seeing the cities of the world fought over," General Sartaq is reported to have said, afterwards, "but I have never seen anyone being attacked like this and, to the end, not surrendering." The Mongols attacked Kuju with catapults, with siege towers, with tunnels, with flaming fagots soaked in human fat; only when Choe-U himself authorized the surrender of the city did the commander, Pak So, open the gates. Sartaq, in admiration, spared his life.[3]

The Mongol invasion pushed through the north of the country, getting closer and closer to the capital city Kaesong, until by the end of the year